

Paths in Polynomial Lemniscates: A Degree-Seven Counterexample and Radial Connections

Erdős Problem #1041, with a Lean proof for the polynomial constructed by ani

WILL COOK*

29 September 2026

ABSTRACT

A monic polynomial of degree seven can have all its zeros in the open unit disc while every connected subset of $\{|f| < 1\}$ containing two zeros has Hausdorff measure greater than 2. We give the polynomial constructed by ani and prove the estimate by confining the cut between two inverse sheets to a small disc. For monic trinomials whose zeros lie in the open unit disc, the root equation keeps every root-to-origin segment inside the lemniscate. Further remarks record analytic short-path criteria whose formal proofs still require additional inputs.

1 Introduction

For a monic polynomial f , write

$$\Omega_f = \{z : |f(z)| < 1\}, \quad K_t(f) = \{z : |f(z)| \leq t\}.$$

Erdős, Herzog and Piranian [2, Problem 5, p. 139] asked whether two zeros in the open unit disc could always be connected by a short curve in Ω_f . Their question is listed as Problem 1041 in Bloom's catalogue [1].

Problem 1.1 (Erdős #1041). Let $f(z) = \prod_{i=1}^n (z - z_i)$ be monic with $n \geq 2$ and all z_i in the open unit disc. Must two root occurrences be joined by a curve of length less than 2 inside $\{|f| < 1\}$?

A repeated root allows a constant curve between two occurrences, so we consider distinct zeros. Pendyala [4, Theorem 1 and Lemma 1] proved the degree-four case using a close-pair chord or radial segments through the centre of a smallest enclosing disc. In degree seven the answer is negative. The example was constructed by the erdosproblems.com contributor [ani](#).

**Authorship and AI use.* Will Cook built and directed the research infrastructure and reviewed the claims when he could. AI agents did most of the research and drafting. Cook did not independently verify every claim.

Theorem 1.2 (ani’s degree-seven example). *The monic polynomial f in (2) has seven distinct zeros in the open unit disc. Every connected set $K \subset \Omega_f$ containing two of its zeros satisfies $\mathcal{H}^1(K) > 2$.*

Lean

Here $\mathcal{H}^1$ is one-dimensional Hausdorff measure. Applied to a path image, the theorem also rules out a rectifiable path of total variation less than 2. Its proof uses one component of Ω_f containing two zeros; the other five components each contain one. On the selected component, f is a double cover of the value disc. We remove an outward slit from its critical value and show that the whole preimage of the slit lies near the critical point. Any connection between the two zeros must therefore approach that point on both inverse sheets. Their combined radial distances, even after the small loss at the slit, exceed 2.

We first prove this geometric estimate, then choose the coefficients needed to apply it. Section 3 gives the contrasting positive result: for $z^n + az^m + b$, the root equation bounds the polynomial on every root-to-origin segment. Four nonzero terms can already defeat a prescribed segment. Sections 4 and 5 collect unformalised analytic remarks on small or isolated critical values. Their arguments, given in full in the companion, are independent of the counterexample and the trinomial theorem.

For the analytic arguments we use the component-wise Riemann–Hurwitz calculation of Ebenfelt, Khavinson and Shapiro [8, proof of Proposition 2.1] together with Pólya’s area inequality in the forms given by Crane [7, Theorems 1 and 6]. Inverse branches, slit domains and capacity also occur in Crane’s work on Smale’s mean-value conjecture [17, Lemma 2.1 and §§2–4], whose derivative normalisation differs from the monic normalisation here. The companion paper gives the rational tests for the degree-seven polynomial and the full arguments underlying Sections 6–7.

2 A component with a narrow bottleneck

2.1 A length estimate for a double cover

Suppose that a component contains only two zeros and one simple critical point. Cutting the value disc from the critical value out to its boundary separates the component into two inverse sheets. We will make the preimage of that cut small by controlling the quadratic term at the critical point.

Lemma 2.1. *Let p be a polynomial and U a component of $\{|p| < 1\}$ on which p has degree two, with one simple critical point c and $v = p(c) \neq 0$. Write $p(c + z) - v = z^2 A(z)$ and put $M = |A(0)|$, $\delta = 1 - |v|$. Let $h > 0$. If $|A(z)/A(0) - 1| \leq 1/4$ for $|z| \leq h$ and $\delta < Mh^2/4$, then every connected subset K of U containing its two roots a, b satisfies*

Lean

$$\mathcal{H}^1(K) \geq |a - c| + |b - c| - \frac{8}{3} \sqrt{\delta/M}.$$

Proof. Put $r_0 = (4/3)\sqrt{\delta/M} < 2h/3$ and cut the value disc along $J = \{tv : 1 \leq t < 1/|v|\}$. Its complement is simply connected and contains no critical value, so the preimage in U has two inverse sheets U_1, U_2 , one containing each zero. On $|z| = r_0$ we have

$$|p(c + z) - v| \geq \frac{3}{4} Mr_0^2 = \frac{4}{3} \delta.$$

Rouché's theorem gives exactly two preimages in $B(c, r_0)$ of every point of J . To see that they are the preimages belonging to U , continue them from the double zero at c as the value moves from v out along the slit. They cannot cross the circle just estimated, and their values remain in the unit disc. They therefore stay in U and, since $p|_U$ has degree two, exhaust its fibre. In particular, $p^{-1}(J) \cap U \subset B(c, r_0)$.

We now use connectedness without choosing a parametrisation of K . If $r_0 < t < |a - c|$ and $K \cap U_1$ missed the circle $|z - c| = t$, then $K \cap U_1 \cap \{|z - c| > t\}$ would be both open and closed in K : outside $B(c, r_0)$, the boundary of U_1 cannot meet U . This set contains a and excludes b , a contradiction. The radial projection $z \mapsto |z - c|$ thus maps $K \cap U_1$ onto an interval of length at least $(|a - c| - r_0)_+$. It is 1-Lipschitz, whence

$$\mathcal{H}^1(K \cap U_1) \geq (|a - c| - r_0)_+.$$

Add the corresponding inequality on U_2 . Hausdorff outer measure is additive across disjoint open sets, so this step needs no measurability assumption on K and gives the stated lower bound. $\square$

2.2 The polynomial

To apply the lemma we need the two zeros to be almost opposite and the critical value to be close enough to the unit circle that the loss at the slit is smaller than the excess in their combined distances. The following coefficients achieve this at one fixed scale. Put $s = 10^{-6}$, $\varepsilon = s^2 = 10^{-12}$ and $\rho = 1 - s^{16}$, and let

$$\begin{aligned} A &= -\frac{329507}{1600}, & B &= \frac{551827}{800}, & C &= -\frac{23013813}{32000}, \\ a &= A - is, & b &= iB + \frac{9}{5}s, & c_0 &= -C - \frac{162}{25}is. \end{aligned}$$

Define

$$F(z) = z^7 - 1 + \varepsilon^4(az^3 - \bar{a}z^4) + \varepsilon^5(bz^2 - \bar{b}z^5) + \varepsilon^6(c_0z - \bar{c}_0z^6), \quad (1)$$

$$f(z) = \rho^7 F(z/\rho). \quad (2)$$

Since $F(z) = -z^7 \overline{F(1/\bar{z})}$, we locate its roots by applying the Cayley substitution $z = (1+ix)/(1-ix)$ and checking the signs of a real polynomial at fourteen rational endpoints. The seven resulting intervals account for all zeros ζ_j of F , which are therefore distinct and have modulus one. Thus $b_j = \rho\zeta_j$ lies strictly inside the disc, as required.

To resolve the critical points near the origin, we pass to the scale $z = \rho\varepsilon w$. Write

$$F(\varepsilon w) = -1 + \varepsilon^7 Q(w), \quad Q(w) = c_0 w + bw^2 + aw^3 - \varepsilon \bar{a}w^4 - \varepsilon^3 \bar{b}w^5 - \varepsilon^5 \bar{c}_0 w^6 + w^7.$$

Rouché estimates on six disjoint rational discs locate the six zeros of Q' . Exactly one, w_s , corresponds to a critical value of modulus less than one. It satisfies

$$|w_s - (0.0000000039 + 0.8232474662i)| < 10^{-6}.$$

Let $c_s = \rho \varepsilon w_s$, $v = f(c_s)$, $\delta = 1 - |v|$, and write $f(c_s + z) - v = z^2 A_s(z)$. The finite estimates needed below are

$$M := |A_s(0)| > 180\rho^5\varepsilon^5, \quad \delta < \frac{36}{5 \cdot 10^6} \rho^7 \varepsilon^7, \quad (3)$$

$$|A_s(z)/A_s(0) - 1| < \frac{1}{4} \quad \left(|z| \leq \frac{\rho\varepsilon}{10} \right), \quad |b_3 - c_s| + |b_6 - c_s| > \rho \left(2 + \frac{143}{1000} \varepsilon \right). \quad (4)$$

The subscripts 3,6 refer to Cayley roots in the intervals $(43812, 43813)/10^4$ and $(-4816, -4815)/10^4$.

To identify the two-root component, we join a small disc about w_s to points close to $8\zeta_3$ and $8\zeta_6$ by polygonal arcs in the w -plane. Containment of the four inner segments follows by writing

$$7\varepsilon + \operatorname{Re} Q(w) - \frac{1}{2}\varepsilon^7 |Q(w)|^2$$

in the Bernstein basis of degree fourteen and checking that all fifteen coefficients are positive on each segment. For the remaining radial portions we use the root identity

$$F(t\zeta) = t^7 - 1 + \sum_{k=1}^6 \varepsilon^{7-k} q_k \zeta^k (t^k - t^7), \quad Q(w) = \sum_{k=1}^7 q_k w^k,$$

which gives $|F(t\zeta)| < 1$ for $8\varepsilon \leq t \leq 1$. All rational intervals, vertices and coefficient tests are specified in [the companion's finite verification](#). Riemann–Hurwitz now shows that this component contains exactly two roots and every other component contains one.

Proof of Theorem 1.2. Apply Lemma 2.1 to the component containing b_3, b_6 , with $h = \rho\varepsilon/10 > 0$. The finite estimates give $\sqrt{\delta/M} < \rho\varepsilon/5000$ and $\delta < Mh^2/4$. Every connected set in that component containing the two zeros therefore has measure greater than

$$\rho \left(2 + \left(\frac{143}{1000} - \frac{8}{15000} \right) \varepsilon \right) > 2.$$

All other components contain one zero. A connected set containing two zeros must lie in the component just considered, which proves the theorem. $\square$

The choice $s = 10^{-6}$ is fixed throughout. Extending these estimates to the small-parameter family reported by ani remains unproved here. The argument estimates the measure of the connected set itself; a bound for the total variation of a chosen parametrisation would not suffice.

3 Trinomials and radial segments

The trinomial identity makes a prescribed path available. At a zero, the constant term and the leading monomial determine every partial sum; both have modulus less than one.

Theorem 3.1 (all-degree monic trinomials). *Let $1 \leq m < n$ and*

$$f(z) = z^n + az^m + b,$$

[Lean](#)
[Comparator](#)

with every zero in the open unit disc. For any zero ζ , the entire segment $[0, \zeta]$ lies in $\{|f| < 1\}$. Distinct zeros ζ_1, ζ_2 are therefore joined by the broken line $\zeta_1 \rightarrow 0 \rightarrow \zeta_2$ of length $\|\zeta_1\| + \|\zeta_2\| < 2$ inside the open unit lemniscate.

Proof. Fix a zero ζ . Eliminating $a\zeta^m$ with the root equation gives

$$f(t\zeta) = b(1 - t^m) + \zeta^n(t^n - t^m).$$

Vieta's formula gives $|b| < 1$. For $0 \leq t < 1$, both $1 - t^m$ and $t^m - t^n$ are nonnegative, and hence

$$|f(t\zeta)| \leq |b|(1 - t^m) + |\zeta|^n(t^m - t^n) < 1 - t^n \leq 1.$$

At $t = 1$ the value is zero. We join any two distinct zeros by concatenating their segments through the origin. $\square$

The same calculation has a useful partial-sum form. Write $f(z) = \sum_{k=0}^n a_k z^k$, take a zero ζ , and put $S_j = \sum_{k=0}^j a_k \zeta^k$. Abel summation gives

$$f(t\zeta) = \sum_{j=0}^{n-1} (t^j - t^{j+1}) S_j.$$

For $t < 1$, division by $1 - t^n$ expresses the value as a convex combination of the S_j . In the trinomial case these are b and $-\zeta^n$. Additional coefficients introduce further partial sums, whose moduli need not be controlled by the root locations.

Proposition 3.2 (failure of a prescribed radial segment). *There exist $r \in (0, 1)$ for which every zero of*

$$f_r(z) = z^6 + \frac{1}{5}r^2z^4 - \frac{1}{5}r^4z^2 - r^6$$

lies in the open unit disc, yet the radial spoke from the origin to the zero r leaves $\{|f_r| < 1\}$.

Proof. We substitute $z = rw$ and factor the polynomial as $r^6(w^2 - 1)(w^4 + \frac{6}{5}w^2 + 1)$, whose six zeros have modulus r . At the midpoint of the positive spoke, $f_r(r/2) = -(327/320)r^6$; choosing $320/327 < r^6 < 1$ proves the assertion. $\square$

This failure concerns the prescribed spoke only. In Section 6.2 we use the partial-sum identity again, first for power substitutions in a cubic and then for a quintic whose two missing coefficients select a suitable pair of segments.

4 A small least critical value

For a squarefree polynomial, let $\mu = \min_{f'(c)=0} |f(c)| > 0$. Its root components are separate below that level, so we follow a component from its first merger and ask how fast its area must grow if every connection between roots is long. The ordinary argument in the companion compares that growth with Pólya's area bound and gives the following unformalised criterion.

Remark 4.1 (unformalised small-critical-value assertion). Let f be squarefree and monic of degree $n \geq 2$, and let μ be its least critical-value modulus. If $\mu \leq 13/25$, then two distinct roots are joined inside $\{|f| < 1\}$ by a rectifiable curve of length strictly less than 2.

Lean
Comparator

This assertion has an ordinary analytic argument and an exact rational comparison, but no Lean proof. The argument is recorded at [the small-critical-value proof](#).

Remark 4.2 (scaling of the preceding assertion). Every squarefree monic polynomial of degree $n \geq 2$ has two distinct roots joined in $\{|f| < (25/13)\mu\}$ by a curve of length less than

$$2((25/13)\mu)^{1/n}.$$

In every degree the length can be chosen less than $(5/2)\mu^{1/n}$.

Lean checks this scaling implication under the named input `LowCriticalThirteenTwentyFifths`, the unformalised assertion in Remark 4.1.

Scaling implication. For $n \geq 3$, apply the preceding assertion to $g(z) = s^{-n}f(sz)$, where $s = ((25/13)\mu)^{1/n}$. Its least critical-value modulus is $13/25$, and rescaling its connection gives the first bound. The estimate $2(25/13)^{1/n} < 5/2$ holds for $n \geq 3$. For $n = 2$, write $f(z) = (z - h)^2 - d^2$ and use the root segment, of length $2|d| = 2\sqrt{\mu}$, contained in $K_\mu(f)$. $\square$

4.1 The analytic argument

Suppose that no pair can be connected with length less than 2 in Ω_f . At a regular level $t \in (\mu, 1)$ we take the component C_t containing a chosen first merger and write $a = \text{Area}(C_t)/\pi \leq 1$, $x = \log(t/\mu)$. Uniformising C_t by the disc, the Bergman segment estimate bounds the length between roots at hyperbolic distance d by $\sqrt{2a \log \cosh(d/2)}$. Our failure assumption therefore forces pairwise distance at least D , where $\cosh(D/2) = e^{2/a}$.

Choose the centre of this uniformisation on a connected set through the first pair in $K_\mu(f)$, outside every intrinsic open unit ball centred at a root. Such a point exists: those balls are pairwise disjoint under the failure assumption and cannot cover a connected set containing two roots. If d_j are the distances of the roots from this centre, the one-root Bergman estimate and the finite Blaschke product for f/t give

$$\lambda(d_j) \leq \frac{1}{2}\delta(a), \quad \sum_j \lambda(d_j) \geq x, \quad \lambda(d) = -\log \tanh(d/2), \quad \delta(a) = -\log(1 - e^{-1/a}).$$

The passage through a first merger, including simultaneous mergers, is part of the analytic input still to be formalised.

We intersect the disjoint hyperbolic balls of radius $D/2$ with a single circle of radius r . Their angular half-widths satisfy

$$w(d, r) = \arccos\left(\text{clamp}_{[-1,1]} \frac{\cosh d \cosh r - \cosh(D/2)}{\sinh d \sinh r}\right), \quad \sum_j w(d_j, r) \leq \pi.$$

This circle-slice inequality is formalised separately. If nonnegative weights σ_i at radii r_i give $\lambda(d) \leq U + \sum_i \sigma_i w(d, r_i)$ for every admissible d , where $U > 0$, summing at the k roots gives

$$k \geq \frac{x - \pi \sum_i \sigma_i}{U}. \tag{5}$$

The circle must be fixed before taking these intersections: angular projections of disjoint balls at different distances can overlap.

To obtain area growth, lift one common value radius from all k roots to ∂C_t , and join successive endpoints by boundary arcs. Splitting the lift integral at level μ gives mean total length at most $\sqrt{ka(x+2)}/2$. The sum of the k adjacent-root connections counts each lift twice and the boundary once, so $2k \leq \sqrt{2ka(x+2)} + \mathcal{H}^1(\partial C_t)$. Combining this with $\mathcal{H}^1(\partial C_t)^2 \leq 2\pi k t (d/dt) \text{Area}(C_t)$ yields the ordinary differential inequality

$$a'(x) \geq \frac{1}{2\pi^2} [2\sqrt{k} - \sqrt{2a(x)(x+2)}]_+^2. \quad (6)$$

The companion proves the lift estimate and accounts for the nonnegative area jumps at merger levels.

4.2 The recorded rational comparison

Equation (5), the bound $k \geq 2x/\delta(a)$ and the companion's two further packing estimates give an integer lower bound for k . Starting from $a(3/10^5) > 10^{-6}$, the recorded rational calculation reaches $a > 1$ by

$$X = \frac{635762889599}{10^{12}}.$$

It used 18 area levels, 126 certified weighted inequalities and a maximum step $1/400$. To certify U on an interval $[u, v]$, it bounds the expression by $\lambda(u) - \sum_i \sigma_i \min(w(u, r_i), w(v, r_i))$; the tail is bounded directly by λ . Numerical optimisation proposes the weights, while rational inequalities bound the whole half-line. The recorded comparison gives $(13/25)e^X < 0.982000386 < 1$. It also gives $(529/1000)e^X < 0.998996547$, so the ordinary argument supports that sharper threshold as well. Neither threshold is claimed optimal, and this arithmetic does not formalise the analytic reduction.

A related ordinary averaging argument, also unformalised in its analytic construction, gives the following bounds. For a monic polynomial of degree $n \geq 2$, two zero occurrences can be joined in $K_{2\mu}(f)$ with length at most $(71/10)\mu^{1/n}$; they are distinct in the squarefree case, and a repeated root gives a constant path. When $\mu \leq 1/2$, the argument gives a path of length at most 5.7 in Ω_f . Its complete proof and the component-arity and capacity variants are in the [inverse-ray averaging argument](#).

5 An isolated simple critical value

The next ordinary construction continues the two branches meeting at a simple critical point over a disc free of other critical values. It leads to a different sufficient condition from small μ . Its square-root map, Bergman estimate and component-area bound are combined in the unformalised input `DiscSepBergmanArea`; the formal algebraic consequences are conditional on that construction.

Remark 5.1 (unformalised isolated-value assertion). Let f be monic of degree $n \geq 3$, let c be a simple critical point, and put $v = f(c) \neq 0$. Fix $w_0 \in [0, 1]$ and $S > \max(w_0, 1 - w_0)$.

Lean[†]

Suppose every other critical point d satisfies

$$\left| \frac{f(d)}{v} - w_0 \right| \geq S.$$

Put $p = w_0(1 - w_0)$. Then two distinct roots are joined inside $\{|f| \leq |v|\}$ by a curve Γ satisfying

$$\text{length}(\Gamma)^2 \leq 2|v|^{2/n} \left(\frac{S}{n-1} \right)^{2/n} \log \frac{S^2 + S + p}{S^2 - S + p}. \quad (7)$$

Lean assumes `DiscSepBergmanArea`: existence of the square-root connector, its Bergman length bound and the area bound for the two-sheeted component. The complete ordinary argument is in the [companion's separation proof](#).

For example, $f(z) = z^3 - 3a^2z$ with $0 < a < 1/\sqrt{3}$ has zeros $0, \pm\sqrt{3}a$. At $c = a$ its critical value is $v = -2a^3$ and the other normalised critical value is -1 . Thus the disc with centre $w_0 = 1$ and radius $4/3$ satisfies the separation hypothesis.

Remark 5.2 (conditional numerical thresholds). Let f be monic of degree $n \geq 3$ with all roots in the open unit disc. If c is a simple critical point with $0 < |f(c)| < 1$ and, for some $w_0 \in [0, 1]$, every other critical point d satisfies

Lean†

$$\left| \frac{f(d)}{f(c)} - w_0 \right| \geq \frac{4}{3},$$

then two roots are joined inside $\{|f| < 1\}$ by a curve of length strictly below 2. In degree three the branch-centred choice $w_0 = 1$ already works with $4/3$ replaced by $6/5$.

The geometric conclusion assumes the construction in [Remark 5.1](#). Lean checks the numerical inequalities for $4/3$ and $6/5$ without that input.

5.1 Square roots and component area

Here is the ordinary argument behind the two remarks. Choose $\alpha^n = v$ and normalise to $P(z) = v^{-1}f(c + \alpha z)$. The component U above $D(w_0, S)$ containing 0 has degree two, as follows by exhausting with regular discs and applying Riemann–Hurwitz. The square root $\xi = \sqrt{1 - P}$ then maps U biholomorphically onto $V = \{\xi : |\xi^2 - (1 - w_0)| < S\}$, and its inverse maps $[-1, 1]$ to the proposed connection.

Put $a = 1 - w_0$ and $p = w_0(1 - w_0)$. The coordinate

$$\zeta = \xi \sqrt{\frac{S}{S^2 + a\xi^2 - a^2}}$$

sends V to the unit disc and $\xi = \pm 1$ to $\zeta = \pm q$, where $q^2 = S/(S^2 + p)$. The Bergman estimate is consequently

$$L^2 \leq \frac{2}{\pi} \log \frac{S^2 + S + p}{S^2 - S + p} \text{Area}(U).$$

For the remaining area estimate, the companion uses an exterior map of a regular component W containing $k < n$ roots. Reflecting the $n - k$ exterior-root factors into the

disc gives a Blaschke product B with $|B(0)| = \text{cap}(\overline{W})^n/t$ and $|B'| < n$ on the boundary. Summing reciprocal derivatives over the fibre opposite $B(0)$ gives $(n - k)/n < (1 - |B(0)|)/(1 + |B(0)|)$, or equivalently $\text{cap}(\overline{W})^n/t < k/(2n - k)$. For $k = 2$, this inequality and Pólya's area–capacity inequality [15, printed pp. 280–282], [7, Theorem 6], followed by exhaustion, give $\text{Area}(U) \leq \pi(S/(n - 1))^{2/n}$. We restore the length scale $|v|^{1/n}$ to obtain (7). Dubinin's relative area inequality [14, Theorem 1] has a different full-covering hypothesis; the absolute component estimate is needed here.

For the conditional threshold, decrease S to $4/3$. Since $p \geq 0$ and $n \geq 3$, the logarithm is at most $\log 7 < 2$ and $(S/(n - 1))^{2/n} \leq 1$, giving $L < 2|v|^{1/n} < 2$. For $n = 3, w_0 = 1, S = 6/5$, use $(3/5)^{2/3} \log 11 < 2$. The chosen critical value must be nonzero and have modulus less than one. Root locations by themselves do not isolate it from the others.

6 Further estimates

6.1 Root distances and component geometry

At a non-root critical point, the balance $\sum_j (c - z_j)^{-1} = 0$ bounds the ratio of the two smallest root distances by $n - 1$. Comparing their sum with the geometric mean of all n distances then gives a bound of $2r$, where $r^n = \prod_j |c - z_j|$.

The root-disc hypothesis gives a different estimate: at every non-root critical point the sum of the two nearest-root distances is strictly less than 2. Both arguments and their precise statements are in the companion's [root-distance estimates](#).

These distance estimates alone do not imply containment. For the quintic

$$(z - a)(z^2 + p^2) \left(z^2 + \frac{902}{901}pz + p^2 \right), \quad p = \frac{999}{1000}, \quad a = \frac{901}{902}p,$$

all roots lie in the disc and 0 is a non-root critical point, but its unique nearest-root segment leaves the unit lemniscate. Moreover, every root-pair midpoint of $z^3 - (99/100)^3$ lies outside it. The [exact counterexamples](#) include the escape calculations.

The cubic $z^3 + 3z/100 - 3/4$ illustrates the restrictions in our sufficient conditions: its least critical-value modulus exceeds $13/25$, while its two normalised critical values are too close for the isolation criterion.

A further cubic has two roots at its first merger but normalised component capacity one at level 2μ . The normalisation uses the standard identity $\text{cap}(K_t(f)) = t^{1/n}$ [23, Theorem 5.2.5 and p. 153].

Finally, $z^8 - (3/2)z$ has a one-root unit-level component with perimeter larger than the proposed constant $\Gamma(1/4)^2/(2\sqrt{\pi})$. These examples, with full calculations, appear in [the companion's component examples](#). The last example has no root-disc restriction and disproves that specific perimeter constant. The existence of a uniform perimeter constant remains a separate question. Although [21, Proposition 2] reports a Runge construction of unbounded one-root perimeters, its proof is unavailable and we do not use it.

6.2 Sparse families and binomial chords

Suppose that all zeros lie in the open unit disc. The radial argument extends to $P((z - h)^q)$ when $q \geq 2$ and P is a monic cubic: if there are two distinct zeros, some such pair has a two-segment connector.

For $z^5 + az^4 + bz + c$, a harmonic-moment identity selects two root indices with $|bz_j + c| < 1$, after which Abel summation controls the whole segments. The companion gives the [cubic-fibre proof](#) and the [quintic selection argument](#), including repeated root occurrences.

For $z^n - r^n$, $0 < r < 1$, the maximum modulus on a chord between adjacent points of radius $s \leq r$ is $r^n + (s \cos(\pi/n))^n$. Thus the outer root chord works below $r_* = (1 + \cos^n(\pi/n))^{-1/n}$. At and above this value, radial legs and a slightly contracted inner chord give open containment and length less than $2r$. The [chord calculation](#) proves the maximum on the entire segment; it makes no assertion of geodesic optimality. For $n = 2$, use the diameter.

6.3 Collinear roots

For collinear roots of diameter D , a Chebyshev alternation argument gives two adjacent root occurrences whose segment satisfies

$$|f| \leq \frac{(D/2)^n}{2^{n-1} \cos^n(\pi/(2n))}.$$

The constant is sharp, with equality for the appropriately scaled zeros of T_n . Qualitative existence of a contained root segment was already proved in [2, Theorem 1]. We compare with the monic minimax polynomial (see Eremenko and Yuditskii [10, §1 and Theorem 1] for the critical-sequence viewpoint). The companion contains the [alternation proof and equality case](#).

6.4 Critical-value means

A weighted Poisson identity gives another consequence of the root-disc hypothesis. For $c_j \in \mathbb{D}$ and positive weights of sum one, set $G(z) = \prod_j |1 - \bar{c}_j z|^{w_j}$. Then $\sum_j w_j G(c_j)^2 \leq 1$, with equality only when all $c_j = 0$. For interior points, we form the analytic product $g(z) = 1 + \sum_{\nu \geq 1} a_\nu z^\nu$ with $|g| = G$. The weighted Poisson kernel is $P = 1 - 2 \operatorname{Re}(\zeta g' / g)$, and

$$\sum_j w_j G(c_j)^2 \leq \int |g|^2 P \, dm = 1 - \sum_{\nu \geq 1} (2\nu - 1) |a_\nu|^2.$$

Radial contraction gives the boundary case.

The reflected derivative transfers the quadratic inequality to $\sum_{j=1}^{n-1} |f(c_j)|^{2/(n-1)} \leq (n-1)R^{2n/(n-1)}$ when the zeros lie in a closed disc of radius R . An unformalised refinement, recorded as an ordinary argument, uses g^2 in the same Poisson integral and gives the proposed fourth-power bound

$$\sum_{j=1}^{n-1} |f(c_j)|^{4/(n-1)} \leq (n-1)R^{4n/(n-1)}$$

for the same enclosing disc. Equality is attained by $(z - h)^n - \lambda$ with $|\lambda| = R^n$. The companion supplies the [weighted identity, reflected-derivative comparison and equality analysis](#).

The quadratic specialisation implies Dubinin's sharp critical-value product bound by AM–GM [16, Theorem 2]. With a zero prescribed at the disc centre, his Theorem 3 gives a different, sharper product estimate and credits earlier work of Tischler [20, p. 444, as discussed by Dubinin]. The corresponding marked-zero positive-moment question in [21] remains unresolved here. To turn any of these mean bounds into a short-path theorem, one would still have to select a pair of roots and control a curve joining them inside the lemniscate.

6.5 Successive merger scales

For a component with k roots and a ratio r of successive merger levels, an integral arising in length estimates is

$$I_k(r) = \int_r^1 \frac{dq}{q \log((1 + q^{2/k})/(1 - q^{2/k}))} = k\Phi\left(\frac{1}{k} \log \frac{1}{r}\right), \quad \Phi(x) = \int_0^x \frac{dt}{\log \coth t}.$$

Substituting $q = e^{-kt}$ gives the identity. Since the integrand increases from zero, Φ is strictly convex and $\Phi(x)/x \rightarrow 0$ at zero. Even for fixed k , no positive multiple of $k^{-1} \log(1/r)$ is a uniform lower bound for $I_k(r)$. The precise endpoint statement and its proof are retained in the companion's [merger-scale calculation](#).

7 Flow constructions and remaining questions

7.1 Inverse rays and perturbation

The Newton flow $\dot{z} = -f(z)/f'(z)$ satisfies $f(z(t)) = f(z(0))e^{-t}$. Thus its image in the value plane follows a fixed ray. This identity and the Newtonian graph of Shub, Tischler and Williams are used in the form given by Kozen and Stefánsson [6, Lemmas 2.1–2.2 and §2]. The companion retains the [value and finite-endpoint theorems](#).

For a finite interval $[a, b]$, continuity of $f(z(t))$ up to the endpoints extends the interior identity to $f(z(b)) = e^{a-b}f(z(a))$. Nonzero endpoint values therefore lie on the same positive ray. Critical values with distinct arguments exclude such a connection; distinct moduli are insufficient.

A generic constant perturbation separates rays when the original critical values are distinct, but cannot split equal values. The companion records an unformalised argument that a linear perturbation can do so generically. Neither qualitative assertion supplies a numerical perturbation bound that preserves a near-extremal path inequality. The [forbidden-ray locus calculation](#) and the local logarithmic expansion, with remainder $nq^{N+1}/((N+1)(1-q))$ for $q < 1$, specify the available control. At the nearest-root radius that expansion is inapplicable.

7.2 The failed tree estimate

For the Cassini polynomial $z^2 - (9/10)^2$, any connected set containing both roots has length at least $9/5$. The right side of Proposition 12 in the March manuscript [3], even

with its proposed arbitrarily small error, is smaller than $41/25$ before that error. Thus the proposed spanning-tree estimate is false. At a simple saddle the local level set has four sectors, consistently with the lemniscate graph description in [13, Definition 1.2 and Proposition 2.4]. The [Cassini calculation and corrected topological statement](#) separate the metric failure from the valid sheet decomposition.

The full topological reconstruction in that discussion remains unformalised. Cutting outward from critical values to obtain inverse-sheet adjacency is classical; see [16, §1] and [22, §2]. Length control requires additional estimates on the actual pieces and their attachment. An uncut Newton orbit space can even fail to be Hausdorff; it cannot automatically be identified with a finite Reeb graph. The earlier numerical searches in degrees 5, 6, 8, 10 found no counterexample on their tested grids. Such searches neither certify containment along unexamined edges nor prove a quantified statement about all polynomials.

7.3 Restricted extremal problems

The companion records the following ordinary compactness argument, which has not been formalised. In the closed lemniscate $K_1(f)$, a finite infimum of connecting path lengths is attained. At fixed degree, compactness of the closed root-disc class and lower semicontinuity of this infimum allow uniform upper bounds to pass to coefficient limits. These are statements about the closed lemniscate, as proved in the companion's [compactness argument](#). The binomial family approaches length 2. The assertion that the universal extremum is at most 2 is refuted by the degree-seven example; its earlier formulation is not a remaining open problem. Quantitative bounds for restricted classes and for varying degree still require further work.

The precise unresolved questions about cut-open flow strips, attachment lengths and quantitative perturbation are stated in the companion's [final questions](#). The origin-spoke failure for the near-regular-pentagon family has an ordinary, unformalised proof there. The stronger failure asserted in the research addendum [21] for every critical joining point has no available proof and is not used. Likewise the fixed degree-seven proof does not establish the whole small-parameter family.

8 Related results and verification

Eremenko and Hayman's bound $\mathcal{H}^1\{|p|=1\} < 9.173 \deg p$ [9, Theorem 1] concerns the total boundary length. Their connectedness result, the derivative estimate of Eremenko and Lempert [11, Theorem 1], and its equality analysis [12, Theorem A] optimise different quantities from an internal root-to-root path. Kuznetsova and Tkachev [19, Theorems 1–2] study length functions on regular levels; their log-convexity does not imply a uniform one-root perimeter bound at a critical endpoint. Dubinin's four-point distortion theorem [18, Theorem 1 and Corollary 4] assumes a bound on all critical values and has a different normalisation. Pendyala's work on Problem 1120 [5, Definition 1.1 and Theorem 1.2] asks for a path from 0 to the unit circle in the intersection of a lemniscate with the closed disc. Those endpoints and that additional region restriction differ from the present question.

Verification. The supplied Lean sources prove the fixed counterexample for preconnected sets, the negation and answer (False) forms of the Formal Conjectures statement, and the total-variation formulation. They also prove the trinomial theorem and the other formally supported estimates identified in the companion’s [verification notes](#). No fresh Lean build or independent human review is reported here, including review of the correspondence with the 1958 wording. The preceding revision’s full rational replay on 29 September 2026 reproduced the stopping time and 126 dual certificates; those are the computational results cited here. The analytic assertions in Remarks 4.1–5.2, the fourth-power mean and the later topological and compactness arguments remain outside the formal conclusions. The margin links retain the original statement identifiers and their conditional dependencies; they do not promote these remarks to unconditional Lean theorems.

Formal proofs. A result with a kernel-checked Lean proof carries a mark in the margin. *Lean* opens the proof: the declaration itself when one declaration states the whole result, otherwise the list of declarations that together state it. *Comparator* opens the record of an independent check, in which the same statement, written again from Mathlib alone in a separate repository, was compared with our proof by Lean’s Comparator tool, allowing only the three standard axioms. A dagger on the Lean mark means that the Lean proof assumes an input named just below the result. A result without a mark has no Lean proof of its whole statement; what is checked is said below it. The [evidence record](#) gives every declaration, version and check. These checks show that the stated propositions are proved; whether they are the right propositions is a question the reader can settle by comparing them with the text.

Acknowledgements

I thank Wouter van Doorn for advice on mathematical exposition, in particular on explaining restrictive hypotheses, avoiding private terminology and introducing notation only when it helps the reader. His remarks concerned another note; this acknowledgement does not imply that he reviewed or endorsed the mathematics of the present paper.

References

- [1] T. F. Bloom, *Erdős Problems*, problem 1041. <https://www.erdosproblems.com/1041>
- [2] P. Erdős, F. Herzog, and G. Piranian, *Metric properties of polynomials*, J. Analyse Math. **6** (1958), 125–148, doi:[10.1007/BF02790232](https://doi.org/10.1007/BF02790232).
- [3] shtuka, *A Short Path Joining Two Zeros Inside a Polynomial Lemniscate*, manuscript posted 24 March 2026, 48 pp. <https://shtuka123.github.io/1041/main.pdf>
- [4] V. S. Pendyala, *A Degree-Four Lemniscate Path Theorem*, arXiv:[2606.24875v1](https://arxiv.org/abs/2606.24875v1) (2026), doi:[10.48550/arXiv.2606.24875](https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2606.24875).
- [5] V. S. Pendyala, *Shortest paths in polynomial lemniscate sublevel sets and a problem of Erdős*, arXiv:[2606.19178v1](https://arxiv.org/abs/2606.19178v1) (2026), doi:[10.48550/arXiv.2606.19178](https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2606.19178).

- [6] D. Kozen and K. Stefánsson, *Computing the Newtonian graph*, J. Symbolic Comput. **24** (1997), no. 2, 125–136, doi:[10.1006/jSCO.1997.0118](https://doi.org/10.1006/jSCO.1997.0118); authors' copy <https://www.cs.cornell.edu/kozen/Papers/newton.pdf>.
- [7] E. Crane, *The areas of polynomial images and pre-images*, Bull. London Math. Soc. **36** (2004), no. 6, 786–792, doi:[10.1112/S0024609304003509](https://doi.org/10.1112/S0024609304003509); preprint arXiv:[math/0302189v1](https://arxiv.org/abs/math/0302189v1), whose statement numbers are cited.
- [8] P. Ebenfelt, D. Khavinson, and H. S. Shapiro, *Two-dimensional shapes and lemniscates*, in *Complex Analysis and Dynamical Systems IV, Part 1*, Contemp. Math. **553**, Amer. Math. Soc., Providence, RI, 2011, 45–59, doi:[10.1090/conm/553/10931](https://doi.org/10.1090/conm/553/10931); preprint arXiv:[1003.4567v1](https://arxiv.org/abs/1003.4567v1), whose statement numbers are cited.
- [9] A. Eremenko and W. Hayman, *On the length of lemniscates*, Michigan Math. J. **46** (1999), no. 2, 409–415, doi:[10.1307/mmj/1030132418](https://doi.org/10.1307/mmj/1030132418); preprint arXiv:[0805.2295](https://arxiv.org/abs/0805.2295).
- [10] A. Eremenko and P. Yuditskii, *Comb functions*, Contemp. Math. **578** (2012), 99–118, doi:[10.1090/conm/578/11472](https://doi.org/10.1090/conm/578/11472); preprint arXiv:[1109.1464v1](https://arxiv.org/abs/1109.1464v1).
- [11] A. Eremenko and L. Lempert, *An extremal problem for polynomials*, Proc. Amer. Math. Soc. **122** (1994), no. 1, 191–193, doi:[10.1090/S0002-9939-1994-1207536-1](https://doi.org/10.1090/S0002-9939-1994-1207536-1).
- [12] A. Eremenko, *A Markov-type inequality for arbitrary plane continua*, Proc. Amer. Math. Soc. **135** (2007), no. 5, 1505–1510, doi:[10.1090/S0002-9939-06-08640-0](https://doi.org/10.1090/S0002-9939-06-08640-0); preprint arXiv:[math/0606745v1](https://arxiv.org/abs/math/0606745v1).
- [13] C. J. Bishop, A. Eremenko, and K. Lazebnik, *On the shapes of rational lemniscates*, Geom. Funct. Anal. **35** (2025), no. 2, 359–407, doi:[10.1007/s00039-025-00704-2](https://doi.org/10.1007/s00039-025-00704-2); preprint arXiv:[2407.14610v1](https://arxiv.org/abs/2407.14610v1).
- [14] V. N. Dubinin, *Some inequalities for polynomials and rational functions associated with lemniscates*, Zap. Nauchn. Sem. POMI **404** (2012), 83–99; English translation, J. Math. Sci. **193** (2013), no. 1, 45–54, doi:[10.1007/s10958-013-1432-4](https://doi.org/10.1007/s10958-013-1432-4).
- [15] G. Pólya, *Beitrag zur Verallgemeinerung des Verzerrungssatzes auf mehrfach zusammenhängende Gebiete*, Sitzungsberichte der Preussischen Akademie der Wissenschaften, Physikalisch-Mathematische Klasse (1928), printed pp. 228–232 and 280–282. <https://archive.org/details/sitzungsbericht1928preu>.
- [16] V. N. Dubinin, *Inequalities for critical values of polynomials*, Sb. Math. **197** (2006), no. 8, 1167–1176, doi:[10.1070/SM2006v197n08ABEH003793](https://doi.org/10.1070/SM2006v197n08ABEH003793).
- [17] E. Crane, *A bound for Smale's mean value conjecture for complex polynomials*, Bull. London Math. Soc. **39** (2007), no. 5, 781–791, doi:[10.1112/blms/bdm063](https://doi.org/10.1112/blms/bdm063); author preprint <https://people.maths.bris.ac.uk/~maetc/SMVCbound.pdf>.
- [18] V. N. Dubinin, *Four-point distortion theorem for complex polynomials*, arXiv:[1301.3985v1](https://arxiv.org/abs/1301.3985v1) (2013).

- [19] O. S. Kuznetsova and V. G. Tkachev, *Length functions of lemniscates*, Manuscripta Math. **112** (2003), 519–538, doi:[10.1007/s00229-003-0411-3](https://doi.org/10.1007/s00229-003-0411-3); preprint arXiv:[math/0306327](https://arxiv.org/abs/math/0306327).
- [20] D. Tischler, *Critical points and values of complex polynomials*, J. Complexity **5** (1989), no. 4, 438–456.
- [21] W. Cook / Plectis, *Three refinements for the lemniscate-path programme*, 16 September 2026, unreviewed research note, Sections 1–3, together with the earlier note *Structural obstructions*.
- [22] V. N. Dubinin, *Lemniscates and inequalities for the logarithmic capacities of continua*, Mat. Zametki **80** (2006), no. 1, 33–37; English translation, Math. Notes **80** (2006), no. 1, 31–35, doi:[10.1007/s11006-006-0105-8](https://doi.org/10.1007/s11006-006-0105-8).
- [23] T. Ransford, *Potential Theory in the Complex Plane*, London Mathematical Society Student Texts 28, Cambridge University Press, Cambridge, 1995, doi:[10.1017/CBO9780511623776](https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511623776).